

MBA: 8109 RESEARCH METHODS



Session 3 — Chapter Two — Literature Review

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Today's Focus: The Five Building Blocks of Chapter Two

1

**Theoretical
Framework**

*Theories &
models that
anchor the
study*

2

Empirical Review

*What prior
studies say —
organised
strategically*

3

Research Gap

*The
unaddressed
space your
study fills*

4

**Conceptual
Framework**

*Your own
diagram of
how variables
relate*

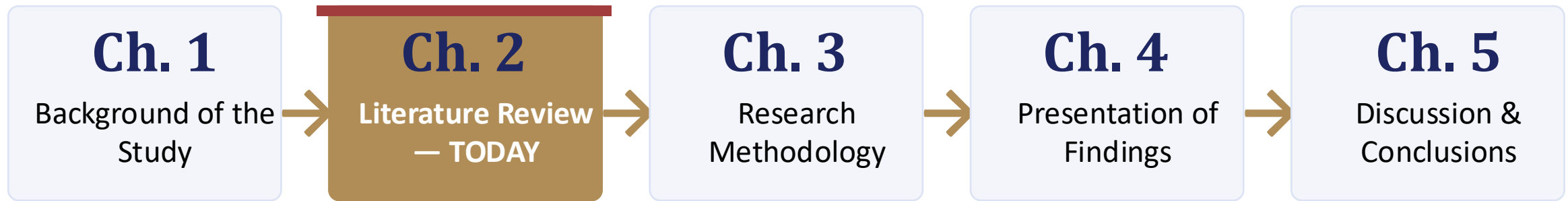
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Operationalisation

*Turning
variables into
measurable
indicators*

Each block answers a different question — together they make Chapter Two argue, not merely describe.

Where Chapter Two Fits in the Dissertation Arc



Chapter Two is where your literature does more than describe — it argues. It shows the theory grounding your study, what the evidence already says, exactly what is missing, your own model of how the variables relate, and how each variable will be measured. Everything here must trace forward into Chapter 3 (methodology) and Chapter 4 (analysis).

01

Theoretical Framework

Anchoring your study in established knowledge

Distinguishing Theory, Model and Framework

THEORY • WHY

Explains WHY a relationship between variables occurs — a coherent causal argument, tested or not (Gill & Johnson, 2002).

EXAMPLE *Resource-Based View — why rare, inimitable resources sustain advantage (Barney, 1991).*

MODEL • HOW

A simplified, often diagrammatic representation of HOW concepts relate — structural and descriptive, usually derived from theory.

EXAMPLE *Porter's Five Forces — how five competitive pressures shape industry profitability.*

FRAMEWORK • WHAT

The scaffolding of the study — the concepts, assumptions and relationships that bound the enquiry and set out WHAT will be examined and measured.

EXAMPLE *Balanced Scorecard — what to measure, across four performance perspectives.*

What theory is NOT (Sutton & Staw, 1995): a list of references, raw data, a list of variables, a diagram of boxes and arrows, or a set of hypotheses — none of these, alone, explains WHY. Strong theory always answers the question 'why would this relationship occur?'

Examples Across Business Disciplines

Discipline	Theory (WHY)	Model (HOW)	Framework (WHAT)
Strategy	Resource-Based View (Barney)	Porter's Five Forces	VRIO
Marketing	Theory of Planned Behaviour	AIDA purchase-funnel model	7Ps marketing mix
Finance	Efficient Market Hypothesis	Capital Asset Pricing Model	Basel III risk framework
OB / HR	Herzberg two-factor theory	Job Characteristics Model	Ulrich HR partner model
Operations	Theory of Constraints (Goldratt)	Economic Order Quantity	Lean Six Sigma DMAIC

Theory vs. Model — Side by Side

Dimension	Theory	Model
Purpose	Explains WHY a relationship exists (causal logic)	Shows HOW concepts/variables fit together
Nature	Abstract, propositional argument	Concrete, often visual/structural
Origin	Built from accumulated, tested reasoning	Often derived from one or more theories
Testability	Generates testable propositions/hypotheses	Applied as a lens or tool; less about proof
Example	Resource-Based View; Diffusion of Innovation Theory	TOE Framework; McKinsey 7-S Model

Identifying & Selecting Appropriate Theories and Models

- **Relevance** — does it genuinely speak to the phenomenon and problem you are studying?
- **Explanatory power** — can it account for the relationships in your specific objectives and research questions?
- **Track record** — has it been applied successfully in similar contexts, sectors, or populations?
- **Construct compatibility** — do its key constructs map onto the variables you intend to study?
- **Level of analysis** — does it operate at the right level (individual, team, firm, industry, macro)?
- **Currency** — is it still a credible lens today, or has it been substantially superseded?
- **Parsimony** — does it explain your phenomenon without needless complexity?

Not All Theories Sit Together — Combining Theories With Care

Why theories can clash

- Different ontological/epistemological assumptions (e.g. positivist vs. interpretivist roots)
- Conflicting views of human agency (e.g. rational-choice logic vs. bounded-rationality/behavioural logic)
- Overlapping constructs that create redundancy rather than insight
- Mismatched levels of analysis (individual-level theory forced onto firm-level data)

How to synthesise well

- Anchor-and-support: one primary theory anchors the study; others fill specific explanatory gaps
- Integrative mapping: assign each theory to the particular variable/relationship it best explains
- Competing-theories test: use two theories deliberately to see which better explains your findings
- Always state explicitly how the theories relate — never simply list them side by side

Aligning Theory to Objectives, Variables & Constructs

Specific Objective	Variable / Construct	Theory / Model Applied	Why This Theory
To establish the effect of digital banking adoption on customer retention	Digital Adoption (IV); Customer Retention (DV)	Technology Acceptance Model (TAM)	Explains adoption behaviour via perceived usefulness & ease of use
To examine the role of employee engagement in service quality	Employee Engagement (IV); Service Quality (DV)	Social Exchange Theory	Explains reciprocity between organisational investment and employee effort
To assess how firm size moderates the strategy–performance link	Firm Size (Moderator)	Resource-Based View (RBV)	Explains how internal resources shape competitive outcomes

02

Empirical Review

What has already been studied — and how to organise it

What an Empirical Review Is — and Isn't



Critical Synthesis

A synthesis of prior data-based studies — not a catalogue giving every source equal, uncritical treatment.



General → Specific

Structured to narrow steadily from the wider field toward your own study's focus.



Thematic, Not Chronological

Organised around ideas — not by date, and not author-by-author.



Contribution • Method • Limitation

Evaluate every study on all three. The limitations are what open the door to your research gap.



Current Thinking

Reflect the most recent evidence available, while still acknowledging seminal, foundational works.

Seven Paths for Organising Your Empirical Review

1 By Variable

One sub-section per independent/dependent variable in your study

2 By Objective

Sub-sections mirror your specific research objectives exactly

3 By Context

Group studies by sector/industry — e.g. banking vs. manufacturing

4 By Region

Global → regional (Africa) → local (Kenya) studies, exposing geographic gaps

5 By Research Design

Group by method used — quantitative, qualitative, mixed, cross-sectional, longitudinal

6 By Findings/Theme

Cluster studies that agree, and contrast those that conflict

Gaps as a 7th path: many strong reviews close each thematic block with 'what is still missing here' — feeding directly into Part 3. Most dissertations combine 2–3 of these paths (e.g. organise by objective, then by region within each).

Capturing Each Study — A Working Template

Author(s) & Year	Objective/ Focus	Context & Design	Key Finding(s)	Limitation / Gap Pointer
Mwangi & Otieno (2023)	Mobile money use and SME growth	Kenya; cross-sectional survey	Positive, significant effect of mobile money on SME turnover	Single-region sample; no moderator tested
Chen et al. (2022)	Digital adoption and firm performance	China; mixed methods	Adoption effect strong only for firms with strong IT capability	Suggests untested moderating role of IT capability
Njoroge (2021)	Financial inclusion and SME survival	Kenya; qualitative case study	Access to credit reduces SME failure in early years	Qualitative only — no generalisable quantitative test

03

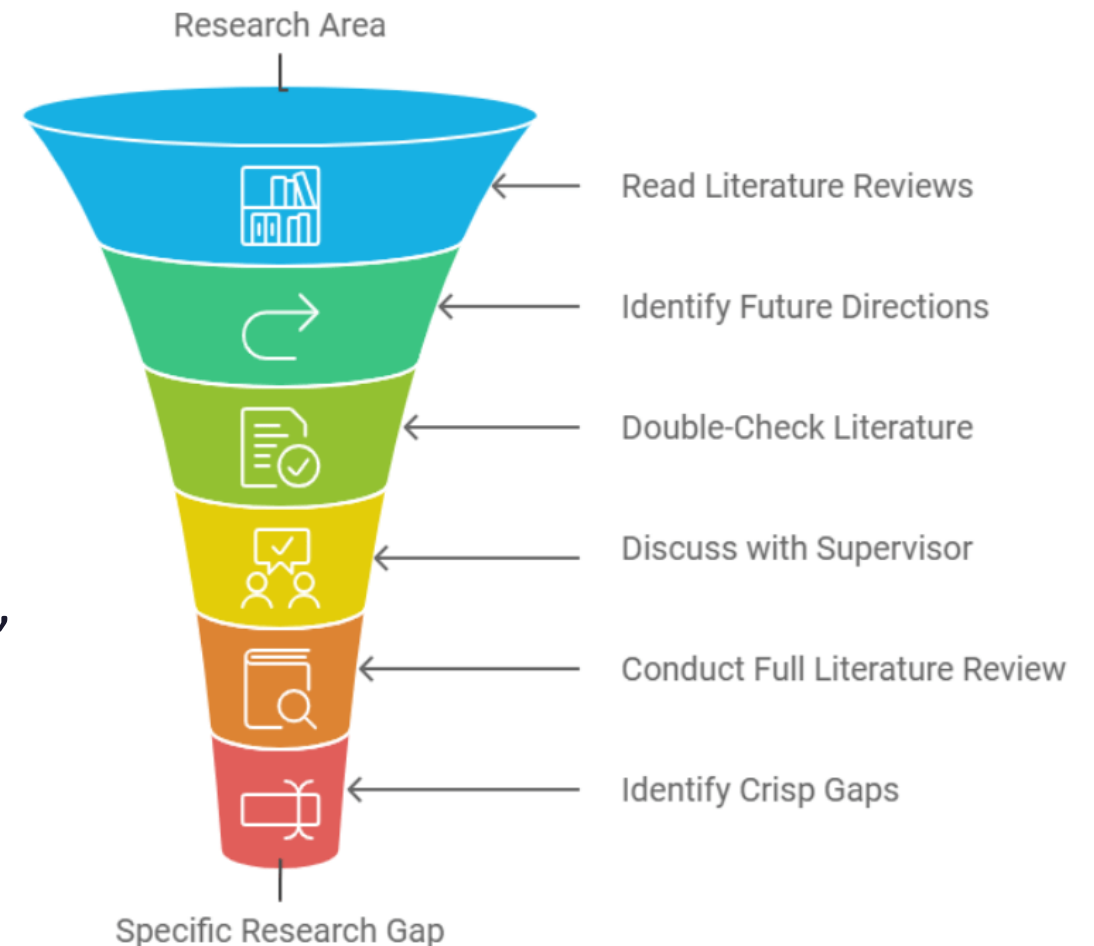
The Research Gap

The unaddressed space that justifies your study

What a Research Gap Is — and Why It Matters

- The specific area that existing literature has not yet adequately addressed — the space your study is designed to fill.
- A gap is not simply 'nobody has done this before' — it must be a meaningful, justified silence in credible literature.
- The gap is the hinge of Chapter Two: everything before it (theory, empirical review) builds the case; everything after it (conceptual framework, objectives) responds to it.
- A well-argued gap directly justifies your title, your objectives, and your contribution to knowledge.

How to Identify Research Gap?



Types of Research Gaps

Theoretical / Knowledge Gap

A theory has not yet been applied, extended, or tested in this way

Methodological Gap

Prior studies relied on limited methods/designs — a different approach is needed

Population / Sample Gap

A different population has not been examined — e.g. SMEs vs. large firms

Conceptual Gap

These particular variables have never been combined/conceptualised together

Empirical / Evidence Gap

Too few empirical studies exist on this specific relationship

Contextual Gap

The sector, industry, or organisational setting has not been studied

Geographical / Regional Gap

The relationship is untested in this country or region

Temporal Gap

Existing evidence is outdated relative to current conditions

Presenting the Gap — A Table That Examiners Look For

Author(s) & Year	Study Focus	Key Finding	Gap Type	How This Study Responds
Chen et al. (2022)	Digital adoption & firm performance in China	Effect strong only where IT capability is high	Contextual + Geographical	Tests the same relationship in the Kenyan SME context
Njoroge (2021)	Financial inclusion & SME survival (qualitative)	Access to credit reduces early-stage failure	Methodological	Adds a quantitative test to strengthen generalisability
Mwangi & Otieno (2023)	Mobile money & SME growth	Positive effect on turnover, no moderator tested	Conceptual	Introduces firm size as a moderating variable

The last column is what examiners look for — every gap you name must be answered by something your study actually does.

04

Conceptual Framework

Your own visual model of how the variables relate

What a Conceptual Framework Is — and Why We Present It as a Figure



Your Reasoned Position

A diagram of how your variables and constructs relate — built from the theory and empirical review before it.



It Is Yours

Derived from the literature, but representing the specific relationships you intend to investigate.



A Figure, Not Prose

A diagram shows structure and direction instantly — far faster than a paragraph.



It Forces Precision

To draw the boxes and arrows you must first decide exactly what role each variable plays.



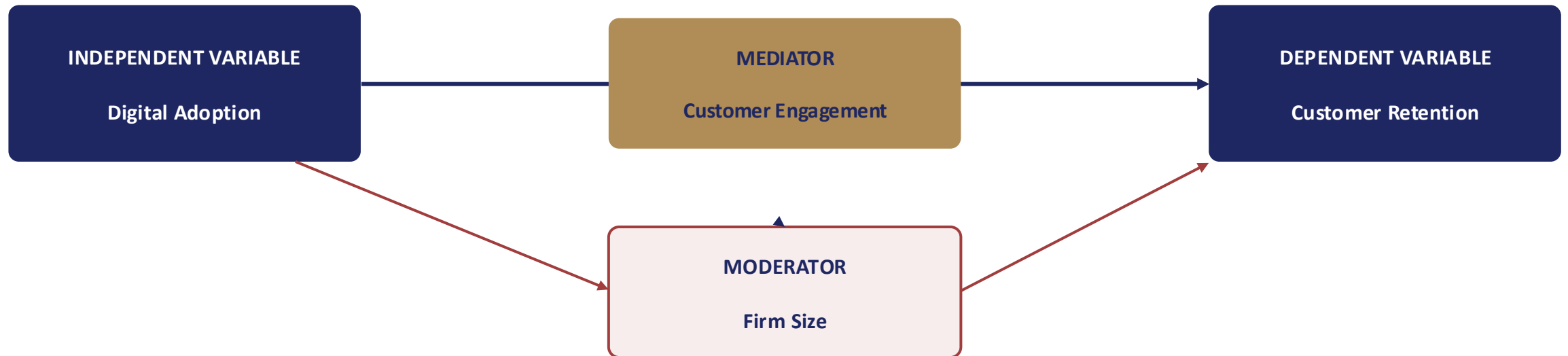
The Visual Anchor

Examiners and readers return to it throughout the rest of the dissertation.

Types of Variables to Illustrate — and What Each Implies

Variable Type	Definition	Implication for the Study
Independent (IV)	The presumed cause or predictor	Must be clearly measurable and manipulable/observable
Dependent (DV)	The outcome being explained or predicted	Drives the choice of analysis technique (e.g. regression)
Moderating	Changes the strength or direction of the IV–DV relationship	Requires an interaction/moderation analysis
Mediating / Intervening	Explains the mechanism through which the IV affects the DV	Requires a mediation analysis (indirect effect)
Control	Held constant to rule out alternative explanations	Must be measured and statistically controlled for
Extraneous	Uncontrolled variable that could confound results if ignored	Must be identified and, where possible, addressed by design

Illustrative Conceptual Framework Diagram



Navy arrow: *direct hypothesised effect.*

Gold box: *mediating mechanism.*

Red path: *moderating influence on the IV-DV relationship.*

05

Operationalisation of Variables

Turning constructs into measurable, analysable data

What Operationalisation Means



Translate the Abstract

Turn every construct in your conceptual framework into concrete, measurable indicators.

Answer "How Will I Measure?"

Exactly how will this variable be observed or measured in the field?

Stay True to the Variable Type

Consistent with its IV / DV / moderator / mediator role and its grounding in theory — Chapter 2 promises must be kept in Chapters 3 and 4.

Present It as a Table

It gets scanned item by item against the instrument, the analysis plan and the findings chapter.

Operationalisation Table — Template & Example

Variable	Indicators/Constructs	Source	Type	Link to Theory/Literature	Measurement Scale	Analysis & Presentation
Digital Adoption	Frequency of use; range of digital services used	Adapted from Davis (1989) TAM scale	Independent	Technology Acceptance Model	Ordinal (5-point Likert); Quantitative	Descriptive stats; regression; tables & bar charts
Customer Engagement	Interaction frequency; responsiveness; loyalty behaviour	Adapted from Vivek et al. (2012)	Mediator	Social Exchange Theory	Ordinal (5-point Likert); Quantitative	Mediation (bootstrap) analysis; path diagram
Customer Retention	Repeat usage rate; account tenure; churn intent	Company records + survey	Dependent	Resource-Based View	Ratio (rate/%) & Ordinal; Mixed	Regression; trend charts

Every variable named in your conceptual framework (Part 4) must appear here — and nowhere new should appear that wasn't in the framework.

Chapter Two — Coherence Checklist

- Every specific objective is traceable to at least one theory in the Theoretical Framework.
- The Empirical Review is organised deliberately (by objective, variable, context, region, or design) — not a list of unconnected summaries.
- Each empirical study reviewed points, explicitly or implicitly, toward a gap.
- The Research Gap table names the gap type(s) and states plainly how your study responds.
- The Conceptual Framework figure contains only variables that appear in your objectives — correctly labelled as IV, DV, moderator, mediator, or control.
- The Operationalisation table accounts for every variable in the framework, with a measurement scale that matches the planned analysis in Chapter 3.

This Week's Practical Deliverable

- A one-page Theory/Model matrix: each specific objective mapped to the theory or model that explains it
- A draft Empirical Review table with a minimum of 8 studies, organised along a chosen path
- A draft Research Gap table naming the gap type(s) your study responds to
- A hand-drawn or digital Conceptual Framework diagram, correctly labelling IV, DV, moderator/mediator
- A first-draft Operationalisation table covering every variable in the framework